

Module 18 · Exam performance

Exam performance: TCF Canada and TEF Canada

Task-by-task strategy, what examiners score, and a four-week plan for the final stretch.

● YOU'LL BE ABLE TO

- ✓ Know the format and timing of every section on both tests
- ✓ Apply a strategy for each listening, reading, writing and speaking task
- ✓ Understand what examiners assess in writing and speaking
- ✓ Follow a structured plan for the last four weeks

Test	Tasks	Length	Strategy
TCF Canada (60 min, 3 tasks)	1: a short message (invite, inform, ask)	60–120 words	Answer every point in the prompt; correct register; greeting and sign-off.
	2: an article, blog post or narrative for readers	120–150 words	Narrate with passé composé + imparfait; describe; give your impression.
	3: compare two short documents and give your opinion	120–180 words	Part 1: summarise both views neutrally (40–60 words). Part 2: argue your view (80–120).
TEF Canada (60 min, 2 sections)	A: continue a news story (fait divers)	80 words minimum	Keep the style of a news article; logical events; past tenses.
	B: a letter or post defending a point of view	200 words minimum	Four-part argument with examples; formal register; connectors.

Test	Task	Timing	Strategy
TCF Canada (≈12 min, 3 tasks)	1: guided interview — talk about yourself	~2 min, no preparation	Family, work, hobbies, plans — with details and at least three tenses.
	2: interaction — get information in an everyday situation	~5 min 30 incl. 2 min preparation	Plan 8–10 varied questions; follow up on answers; polite openings and closings.
	3: express a point of view on a question	~4 min 30, no preparation	Position → reasons with examples → concession → conclusion. Keep talking.
TEF Canada (15 min, 2 sections)	A: obtain information (e.g. about an ad) by phone	~5 min	Ask many well-formed questions in the vous register.
	B: present a document and convince a friend	~10 min	Summarise, give arguments, answer objections, use the conditional.

● KEY PHRASES

Bonjour, je vous appelle au sujet de votre annonce.
Hello, I'm calling about your ad.

Pardon, pourriez-vous répéter la question, s'il vous plaît ?
Sorry, could you repeat the question, please?

C'est une question intéressante. Alors, à mon avis...
That's an interesting question. So, in my view...

Je vais vous donner un exemple concret.
Let me give you a concrete example.

Il est vrai que... mais d'un autre côté...
It's true that... but on the other hand...

Pour résumer, je dirais que...
To sum up, I'd say that...

Merci beaucoup pour votre temps. Bonne journée !
Thank you very much for your time. Have a good day!

● AVOID THESE MISTAKES

~~X Answering the topic you prepared instead of the question asked~~

Task completion is scored first.

✓ **Rephrase the question in your first sentence, then answer it**

~~X Stopping after 90 seconds in a 4-minute task~~

Fluency and development are assessed across the whole task.

✓ **Plan three reasons and examples — enough material for the full time**

~~X Writing 250 words for a 120–150 task~~

Going far over can cost points and time.

✓ **Stay within the range**

~~X Only simple present tense sentences~~

Grammatical range is part of the score.

✓ **Show range: past, future, conditional, relative clauses, one subjunctive**

~~X Spending 5 minutes on one hard reading question~~

Every question is worth the same; later ones may be easier for you.

✓ **Guess, flag, move on**

~~X Memorising a whole model essay~~

Examiners spot memorised text that doesn't fit the prompt.

✓ **Memorise flexible phrases and structures**

● TIP

Keep a personal checklist of your five most frequent errors (from your drill and mock-exam results) and proofread for exactly those. It's more effective than a general re-read.

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Exam performance: TCF Canada and TEF Canada: the rules at a glance

Lesson 18.1

CHEAT CODE Listening, step by step

1

Read the options first
predict: a price? a reason?

2

Who, where, why?
in the first seconds

3

Write numbers down
don't hold them in memory

4

Watch the traps
repeated words,
negations, the final
decision

Lesson 18.2

CHEAT CODE Reading, step by step

1

~90 s per question
they get harder — don't
burn time early

2

Question first
then scan the text

3

What kind of document?
notice, ad, email, article

4

Look for paraphrase
wrong answers copy the
exact words

Lesson 18.3

CHEAT CODE

TCF Canada writing: 60 minutes, 3 tasks

60–120
words**Task 1**A short
message:
invite, inform,
ask120–150
words**Task 2**An article or
story: narrate
and describe120–180
words**Task 3**Compare two
documents,
give your
view

Lesson 18.4

CHEAT CODE

TCF Canada speaking: about 12 minutes

~2 min

**Task 1 ·
interview**Talk about
yourself2 min prep +
3:30**Task 2 ·
interaction**Ask questions
to get
information4:30, no
prep**Task 3 ·
opinion**Give and
defend a
point of view

Lesson 18.5

CHEAT CODE The last four weeks**4 weeks out**Every mock
once. List your
weakest
section and
top 5 errors.**3 weeks out**Weakest
section daily. A
timed task
every other
day.**2 weeks out**Recorded
speaking
simulations,
single-play
listening.**Final week**Light review,
one last mock,
sleep well.